

CHAPTER IX

SIKHS UNDER BRITISH RULE (1849-1947)

Sikhs Pacified by the British 1850-1872

After the annexation of the Sikh empire, the British demobilized the Sikh army by putting over eight thousand Sikhs in jails in the very first year. Most of the Sikh forts were demolished. Sikhs were disarmed and over forty thousand Sikh soldiers were dismissed who went back to their homes to take up the traditional occupation of agriculture, but some of the best Sikh forces were retained in service. A Punjab force was set up consisting exclusively of Sikhs, particularly Sikh jats excluding the weaker sections so as to divide the Sikhs. The *Jagirs* of the Sikh chiefs who had not participated in the Sikh wars against the British were confirmed so as to create a loyal Sikh section towards the British and intensify the divide between the Sikhs, while the *jagirs* of the hostile Sikh chiefs were confiscated or reduced. Some prominent Sikh warriors were sent out of Punjab to face sedition trials. At the same time the British took steps to pacify the Sikhs generally. The British Governor General Lord Dalhousie recorded in 1849 to warn the British government :

"Hatred of Sikhs against the Britishers exceeds the national and religious animosity of Sikhs against Afghans."

The British took the Sikhs as a wounded lion and knew that a wounded lion is very dangerous. They were also in the know about the ups and downs in Sikh history in the struggle against the Mughals and Afghans. National re-unification and reorganization of the Sikhs in order to challenge British rule in the near future was a fear uppermost in the minds of the British. They could also predict that if the Sikhs came into direct conflict with them again, their stay in India may not be prolonged. They knew that they could take over the Sikh state only with the help of conspiracies and betrayals by insincere elements in the Sikh state. So the British planned to pacify the Sikhs and heal their wounds by honouring their religious feelings, their vocations, their life and sense of dignity.

The British were in a difficult situation as to how to deal with the Sikhs. One view was to have a hostile attitude towards the Sikhs by setting up army rule in Punjab

and not allowing them to reunite and have the management of the Sikh gurdwaras under their control through the Mahants who were ever ready to play into their hands to make their offices hereditary. The other view was against such a hostile attitude and rather to set up a civil administration in Punjab, not to interfere in Sikh religious affairs and rather to pacify the Sikhs and help them to settle in vocations of their choice which were mostly army and agriculture. But on the other hand the Punjab Governor wrote to the Viceroy of India on August 8, 1881 to keep the managements of Sikh gurdwaras under their control :

"I think it would be politically dangerous to allow the management of Sikh temples to fall into the hands of committee emancipated from government control and I trust your Excellency will assist to pass such an order in the case as will enable to continue the system which has worked out successfully for more than thirty years."

It predicts the thinking of the first category views that they had been consistently using a hostile attitude in trying to deal with the Sikhs. The British government took a half way course and put it into practice from the very beginning. Neither was there total army rule nor total civil rule; they encouraged Sikh adversaries including the Mahants against the Sikhs, but if the Sikhs display determination to come into conflict with the British, then they were to yield so as not to be in direct confrontation with the Sikhs.

The British appointed a board to look into the administration of Punjab at the very start. It consisted of Henry Lawrence (army and political), his brother John Lawrence (Revenue) and Charles Manson (Law and Justice), Henry was a known opponent of British machinations and bitter over the way the Punjab and the Sikh state had been annexed on the false pretext of a local rebellion and had even sent in his resignation over this matter which had not been accepted by the Governor General and he was rather made the President of the Board. The Sikhs had an affinity towards him for having resisted the annexation of the Sikh state. Also he had prevailed over the commander in chief of the British army Charles Napier who wanted military dictatorship in Punjab and instead he got civilian rule established. Sikhs were recruited into the Army by amending the rules; so they could not only remain baptized Sikhs but also it was ensured that Sikh soldiers must retain the Sikh code of conduct. Large tracts of lands with irrigation facilities were made available to Sikhs to keep them busy in Agriculture.

To honour Sikh religious sentiments and to satisfy the martial spirit of the Sikhs as to their avocation of army service, the British government made amendments in the rules of recruitment to the army, making baptised Sikhs, observing the Sikh code of conduct, and possessing the five Sikh emblems to be eligible to join the army. The regulations and rules provided :

"The pool of religious pledges of Sikh fraternity should on no account be interfered with. The Sikh

should be permitted to wear his beard and the hair of his head gathered up as enjoined by his religion. Any invasion however slight of these obligations would be construed into a desire to subvert his faith, lead to evil consequences and naturally inspire general distrust and alarm. Even those who have assumed the outward conventional characteristics of Sikhs should not be permitted after entering the British army to drop them."

(SC 38 of 28.2.1951)

The Governor General, Lord Dalhousie gave his consent to these regulations and remarked :

"Soon after I entered Punjab during the present march, I heard that Sikhs had been enlisted but that in compliance I presume with existing regulations they had been required to cut their beards-an act to which no real Sikh can submit, or if he for a time submits to it for necessity, it is impossible that he can do so without the deepest discontent. No true Sikh will submit to it and the intelligence that such a regulation is enforced rapidly spreading among other Sikh corps in the service may produce alarm or at least restlessness which is much to be deprecated. This point therefore should at once be set at rest."

(SC 39 of 28.2.1951)

It was recorded by the British in the very next year :

"Sikh soldiers proved their fighting quality and loyalty in the Anglo-Burmese war of 1852 and two years later against the nomad tribe on the North West frontier."

(Baird, *Private Letters of Marquess of Dalhousie*, pp. 200, 321)

In the mutiny of 1857 the British realized that it was the Sikh soldiers who played such a great role in curbing the mutiny. The Sikhs were acknowledged for their brave role in suppressing the mutiny. It was recorded in the secret correspondence of the British :

"The Sikhs were raised at a most crucial season, when other recruiting grounds were in the hands of the mutineers or in a state of rebellion. They were called on to save the empire and have fulfilled their mission and we all owe our warmest thanks to that bold and sagacious policy which called them into the field and which I am sure will also devise means for keeping them under command for future."

(SC 2 of 29.10.1958)

Ultimately the Sikhs formed over thirty percent of the Indian army in British India, though their population was less than two percent. The Sikhs accomplished so much feats of bravery and commitment that they made a name for themselves for their courage; on the battlefield during the World Wars to achieve victories, while maintaining their moral ethics. The British set up separate Sikh Battalions with Gurdwaras in all the cantonments and ensured their observance of the Sikh code of conduct. The turbaned Sikh soldiers and officers in their distinct Sikh appearance and identity could be visible from far off. The British were thus successful in avoiding

conflict with the Sikhs by allowing the Sikhs to take up vocations of their choice namely the army, and giving due regards to their religious sentiments and dignity. In fact the Sikhs were in no mood to be in armed conflict with British due to the intense rivalries of the sons of Maharaja Ranjit Singh, of all the Sikh chiefs, and the betrayals of Sikh commanders and ministers in conspiracy with British officers to defeat Sikh army.

The Britishers took all pains to satisfy the Sikhs as to their main vocation of agriculture. Canals were constructed to take the river waters to the lands mostly occupied by the Sikhs to advance the prospects of agriculture. The desert lands to the west of Punjab were made cultivable by being irrigated by canals and were allotted to Sikhs residing in eastern Punjab on nominal prices so as to keep them busy and occupied and content in their agricultural vocation. The Sikhs particularly the Sikh jats who were involved in agriculture were made the owners of big tracts of land with the facility of irrigation from canal waters. The area specifically selected for Sikhs was huge and vast tract of land known as 'Nilibar' irrigated by the Chenab Canal. The Sikh farmers from the districts of Amritsar, Ludhiana, Ferozepur and adjoining areas were given these lands, giving them a sense of becoming big farm owners. The small land holders were allotted 14 to 16 acres of land, without any payment. The middle land holders were allotted 100 to 150 acres of land at the nominal price of less than ten per acre. The big land holders were allotted 150 to 500 acres of land at a price of less than twenty rupees per acre. The Sikh farmers known for their sense of hard labour made their farms cultivable, capable of producing surplus agricultural produce. The Sikhs thus became the most prosperous peasantry of India, most of them were jat Sikhs.

The canals constructed were Upper Bari Doab, from river Ravi and lower Bari Doab as well from that River; the upper Chenab canal from Chenab river. The Shahpur Thal desert was irrigated by the canals taken from river Jhelum in upper Jhelum canal. These irrigation projects covered entire lands which were previously deserts and made them fit for agriculture from the Chenab river, 427 miles of Canal were taken and 2280 miles of distributor channels, while 12,000 miles of the water course were taken. These channels irrigated 2.25 million acres of land. It was at the cost of twenty six million rupees, the yearly value of the crop yielded over seventy-eight million rupees which was earned mostly by the Sikh farmers. The prosperity of Sikhs and other Punjabis is well exhibited by the report of the financial commissioner of Punjab :

"Cultivation has now become more careful, comfortable and commodious houses have been built. All villages have now a good well, many of these have a mosque or a dharamsala and a rest house; the growth of good shading trees is remarkable both in the villages and fields. Many villages are a pattern of cleanliness and comfort and the people evidently take pride in them and their imposing houses of brick and mortar. There are of course, some exceptions among 1,00,000 colonies, but the general impression is one of good prosperity, comfort and content from which a feeling of gratitude to Government for the extraordinary benefits, its colonization scheme has conferred on these fortunate individuals in the short space of fifteen years is not absent."

(Civil and Military Gazette, May 26, 1909)

The first attempt to erect a cotton mill in the Punjab was made in March 1883 when citizens of Lahore met under the chairmanship of Raja Harbans Singh to consider the matter. (Reported in *The Tribune*, March 18, 1883)

It shows that in addition to the development of lands for agriculture, cotton mills were also being set up. Posts for Sikhs were reserved in the Army and in the civil services as well to be filled exclusively by baptized Sikhs, the Khalsa. It was also a step to recognize Sikh religious sentiments and to keep the Sikhs satisfied, by the British government. Such steps taken by the British government resulted in the increase of Sikhs substantially. The Sikh jats had now become superior to the Brahmins and other castes, because of their being the land owners of the entire village lands and thus being more prosperous. Now others had become dependant upon them, when previously Brahmins were considered to be superior. There was no thought of conflict between Sikhs and the Britishers; instead their co-operation increased. The British with their experience and tactics won over the minds of the Sikhs tactfully.

The British also paid attention to the construction of roads in Punjab to satisfy the people that they were interested and were committed to the overall development of the state. The G.T. road from Peshawar to Delhi was reopened and hundreds of bridges on it were repaired. In the administration report of 1850 and 1851, of two years after the annexation of Punjab, it was stated in para 346 :

"1349 miles of roads have been cleared and constructed while 853 miles are under construction; 2487 miles have been traced and 5272 miles surveyed, all exclusively of minor cross and branch roads."

The British administration provided a more systematic and accountable civil administration. Punjab was divided into 7 divisions or commissionerships which was further divided into districts (of which there were 25 in the province) a five tiered administration was set up. Next to the board were the commissioners of the seven divisions. Below the commissioners were the Deputy and Assistant Commissioners and below them extra Assistant Commissioner, a cadre specially constituted to provide jobs for such natives as might have filled offices of trust under the Darbar. The lowest grade of gazetted officers was the tehsildar whose civil powers extended to deciding cases up to the value of Rupees 300.

For internal security, ten regiments – five cavalry and fifty infantry, were raised. Some of the Darbar's soldiers were absorbed in these regiments. A military police force consisting of 8000 men, largely Punjabi Mussalmans, was raised. The foot constabulary was meant to guard treasuries and goals, the mounted police to petrol highways. A secret intelligence services (*Khufia*) police comprised of informers and detectives (*Jasus*) was attached to the police to keep the government in touch with the political temper of the people. Village watchmen-*Chaunkidars* continued to be employed by the villagers but were expected to keep the police informed of the movements of strangers.

(Khushwant Singh, *History of Sikhs*, Vol. II, p. 90)

Time for Sikh Awakening

British government continued taking a keen interest in Sikh affairs. In 1859 it drafted the rules and regulations for the administration of Harimandar Sahib known as 'Dastur-al -Amal' whereby a manager was to be appointed who was to be guided by a council of nine baptized Sikhs. The sole proprietorship of all Gurdwaras was to be in the Guru, while the claim to management was to vest in Sikh Panth. But the authority of the Government to appoint a manager could never be acceptable to the Sikhs. For some time, the Government appointed the managers of its choice, to be exploited to its advantage but ultimately yielded to the Sikhs and Harimandar Sahib came in to the exclusive management of the Sikhs. Similarly the British administration, initially helped the Mahants to keep them under its obligation, but yielded to the Sikhs when they exhibited their determination to oust them at any cost, thus to avoid confrontation with the Sikhs, and ultimately enacting the Sikh Gurdwaras Act 1925 to vest the management of Sikh Gurdwaras with the Sikhs directly. Time for Sikh awakening to its real tenets had now arrived.

The Mahants and managers of Sikh historical Gurdwaras had become so anti-Sikh under the patronage of the British administration and Brahmanical agents that they even dared to issue a *Hukamnama*, from Takhat Hazur Sahib, Nanded that Sikhs should not give co-operation to the Singh Sabha movement. This was done on the pretext that the Singh Sabha was baptizing Muslims of lower castes and women. Even though *Hukamnama* from Akal Takhat had already been issued in 1879 that Sikhs should join the Singh Sabha movement which was aimed at bringing the desired reformation and restoration to the original form of Sikhism. There can be no objection to the baptizing of any person who is willing to join the Sikh religion, irrespective of the religion, caste or sex one belongs to.

On March 18, 1887 a *Hukamnama* was also issued from Akal Takhat, Amritsar against Prof. Gurmukh Singh, the main spirit behind Lahore Singh Sabha for getting baptized the Muslims and low castes in Singh Sabha Gurdwaras in violation of the basic thought of Sikh religion and the earlier *Hukamnama* of Akal Takhat. Such anti-Sikh actions were obviously beyond the toleration of Sikhs.

Activism of Anti-Sikh Elements

Brahmanical cult was anti-Sikh from the very start, as they had a fear psychosis as to the danger to their false sense of superiority and exploitation of the innocent masses by the Divine teachings of Sikh Religion. They were thus interested in introducing the same Hindu myths, superstitions, gods and incarnations into the Sikh religion which had all been rejected by the Sikh Gurus. Most of the converts to the Sikh religion were from Hinduism. Arya Samaj and other fundamentalist Hindu groups were also active in misrepresenting Sikh religion to be a part of Hinduism and the Sikhs to be a sect of the Hindus. Swami Daya Nand, Arya Samaj leader, came to Punjab

to propagate it and attracted some Sikh leaders with his novel plan that Arya Samaj, like the Sikhs also condemned Idol-worship, caste and creed distinctions and Brahminical domination. But he was committed to Vedantic ideology and its superiority giving a secondary place to the *Guru Granth Sahib* and had even made adverse remarks against the Sikh Gurus. So all the Sikhs turned against him. He had to leave Punjab without fulfilling his mission. Some Sikh scholars negated the propaganda that the Sikhs were a sect of the Hindus. Kahan Singh Nabha wrote a book — *Hum Hindu Nahin* "Hum (Sikhs) are not Hindus". So this propaganda proved counter productive.

Nirankaris, *Radhaswamis* and *Namdharis* were some other groups whose heads were called as 'Satguru' with false notions though they mostly referred to the Sikh scriptures and their divine teachings to be supreme. But in Sikhism there can be no recognition to such Gurus wherein only the ten Sikh Gurus and the *Guru Granth Sahib* are the only Gurus. They caused some confusion in a few Sikhs initially but the Sikhs ultimately rejected them as non -Sikh groups, as in Sikh religion no one is permitted to call himself as Guru and there can be no scope for any such groups. The government agencies tried to exploit them to mislead the Sikhs but the Sikhs faced the challenge with determination to successfully reject such groups to be a part of Sikhism. Baba Ram Singh was misrepresented to be the *Namdhari Guru*, though throughout his life, he remained a devoted and humble Sikh following the Sikh code of conduct strictly and preaching the *Guru Granth Sahib* to be the perpetual Sikh Guru, while attempting to regain Sikh rule. The anti Sikh forces were behind these groups to provide them all the hidden support to misrepresent Sikhs and Sikh religion. The Sikhs thus had to face this challenge and which they did.

Sikhs also had to face another challenge from Christian Missionaries who had become active in Punjab after its annexation by the British, and had the government patronage. They started their missionary schools in which prayers were held in the name of Jesus Christ and the preaching of Christianity was imparted to students. Their *modus operandi* was to lure the people with financial assistance and to serve mankind with the aim of conversions to their religion. Their first encounter with the Sikhs took place at Amritsar where they persuaded four Sikh students to embrace Christianity. This was exposed with the timely action of the Sikhs and the missionaries could not succeed. The Christian Missionaries got the message that they would not be permitted to operate within the Sikh populace; with no objection to their missionary spirit to serve mankind. They abandoned their plans of conversions as far as the Sikhs were concerned, realizing the determination and devotion of the Sikhs towards their religion. The British government had already decided not to interfere in the religious affairs of the Sikhs in order to avoid direct confrontation with them. It had amended the army rules to allow baptized Sikhs as they had felt the commitment of Sikhs to their code of conduct.

A confidential report on the development in Sikh politics (1900-1911) by D. Setrie, Assistant Director Criminal Intelligence, government of India dated 11 August,

1911 (National Archives Delhi) depicts the hostility of the Brahmanical cult and fundamentalist Hindus against Sikhs :

"Hinduism has always been hostile to Sikhism whose Gurus peacefully and successfully attacked the principles of caste which is the foundation on which the whole fabric of Brahmanism has been reared. The activities of Hindus have therefore been constantly directed to the undermining of Sikhism; both by preventing the children of Sikh fathers from taking *Pahul* and by reducing the professed Sikhs from their allegiance to their faith. Hinduism has strangled Buddhism, once a formidable rival to it and it has already made serious in-roads into the domain of Sikhism."

Sikhs were thus to face this challenge.

Singh Sabha Movement (1873 to 1920)

— Sikh Awareness

In 1873 AD, the Sikhs started a movement for Sikh education and Sikh religious reforms known as "Singh Sabha movement". It was to preach the real tenets, the doctrines and the principles and religious practices of the Sikh religion to be strictly followed by the Sikhs. It was to curtail Brahmanical infiltration in Sikh religious places and the spread of Christianity among Sikhs besides setting up of educational institutions, Sikh schools and colleges for Sikh students for their general studies as well as to enable them to live the Sikh way of life. It was also to set up Sikh newspapers and journals which would give the Sikh point of view against the misrepresentations propagated against Sikh religion. It was also done to set up Gurdwaras and to take practical steps to educate and awaken the Sikhs towards correct perspectives. The Sikhs having been peacefully settled in their respective vocations, found the time to give attention to these matters. Even during Sikh rule no such steps could be taken in these matters as the Sikhs remained occupied with the conflicts and battles to establish the Sikh Empire.

Singh Sabha Gurdwaras were set up throughout Punjab, which was the need of the day. Effective steps were taken to set up Sikh schools and colleges in which the teachings of Sikh religion were to be imparted to the students from the very beginning in their childhood. The first Khalsa High school was set up at Gujranwala in 1889 and thereafter Khalsa schools were set up in every important town. Guru Nanak Khalsa College was set up and the foundation stone of it was laid down by Sant Attar Singh who took keen interest in Sikh educational institutions at Mastuana. Later on, a very prestigious Khalsa College was set up at Amritsar in 1892 and likewise, many more institutions also at other places. Sant Teja Singh also did a lot in the field of Sikh education. He himself had achieved distinctions at Oxford University London, and at Harvard University in America.

Effective steps were taken by the Sikhs to promote the Punjabi language in gurmukhi, was published in 1854. The Punjabi Printing Press was set up for the

publication of Sikh literature, journals and newspapers. In 1880 gurmukhi Akhar and vidyak Punjabi were started, while in 1885, *Khalsa Akhar*, in 1886 *Rasala Sadharak* and *Khalsa Gazette* were added. In 1884, Khalsa Tract Society was set up at Amritsar under the driving force of Bhai Kaur Singh and Bhai Vir Singh to preach Sikh religion. The famous tract of Bhai Kahn Singh Nabha, the eminent Sikh scholar, *Ham Hindu Nahin* was published in 1899. Giani Ditt Singh and other Sikh scholars silenced the Arya Samajists and the Brahmanical cult bringing forth a separate Sikh identity based on the correct analysis of the distinctive features of Sikh religion as separate and independent revealed religion and not a part of Hinduism.

Khalsa Diwans

In 1883 Khalsa Diwan was formed with the aim to educate the Sikh youth as to the Sikh way of life and the Sikh code of conduct to be strictly observed by the Sikhs and to organize the Sikh educational institutions. Three types of Sikh leaders came to the fore. First were the hawks led by persons like Thakur Singh Sandhawalia, who were opposed to any co-operator with the British government, second were the moderates led by Kanwar Bikramjit Singh Kapurthala and Bhai Gurumukh Singh who were in favour of cooperation with the British government and third were the Bedis and Sodhis led by Baba Khem Singh Bedi who were desirous of their own superiority, because they belonged to the same clan as the Sikh Gurus.

Due to the difference of ideologies of the leaders of the Khalsa Diwan, two Khalsa Diwans were formed. One was called Khalsa Diwan, Amritsar while the other as Khalsa Diwan Lahore. They operated in their own ways but their aims were the same to educate the Sikh masses and to awaken them to the reality of the Sikh religion.

In 1902, the chief Khalsa Diwan was formed to accommodate all the Sikh leaders and coordinate their activities. Its founder President was Arjan Singh Bagarianwala; while its secretary was Sunder Singh Majithia. The Chief Khalsa Diwan attended to the plans for Sikh educational schemes methodically. The annual educational conferences were also organized. It laid the foundation for Khalsa College Amritsar in 1890 on a vast tract of land with a magnificent architectural construction. Other Sikh colleges and schools were also set up by it.

In 1918 Sikh education committee was formed by the Chief Khalsa Diwan to effectively deal with the Sikh educational affairs. It certainly goes to the credit of the Singh Sabha movement of the Sikh organizations which made the Sikhs conscious as to their education and religion and not to be misled by their adversaries.

In 1905, Sikhs got the idols from the Parkarma of Harimandar Sahib removed. These had been placed by the Mahants under the instigation of the Brahmanical agents though idol worship was totally prohibited in the Sikh religion. Anti Sikh activities in Gurdwaras were exposed and would no more be tolerated. The Sikhs gave clear message to the Mahants that henceforth Gurdwaras would function strictly in accordance with the Sikh religious doctrines and practices.